

Focus Group Protocol for Non-Native English-Speaking Students at BYU

Purpose

To understand the language skills non-native English-speaking students need to succeed academically and socially at BYU, focusing on **Listening/Speaking** and **Reading/Writing**.

Participants and Format

- 5-8 non-native English-speaking students per group.
- Sessions last about 45-60 minutes.
- Responses will be anonymized (no names recorded; use participant codes).

Moderator Role

- Facilitate discussion neutrally.
 - Ensure all participants have equal opportunities to speak.
 - Follow the script but allow flexibility for natural discussion.
 - Assure participants that their input is confidential and only used for research.
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Script

1. Welcome & Ground Rules (5 min)

"Thank you for joining us today. We want to learn about the language skills you use and need while studying at BYU. Everything you share will be kept confidential, and your names will not be connected to your answers. In reports, we will only use group summaries or anonymous quotes. There are no right or wrong answers—we are interested in your experiences. Please respect each other's perspectives and give everyone a chance to speak."

- Ask participants to introduce themselves with a number.
 - Gather permission to record the focus groups. Explain that only researchers will have access to the recordings.
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2. Listening & Speaking Skills (20 min)

- (Show the participants the survey with the frequencies they marked for each linguistic task.) “Do these surveys accurately represent what you have to do in your classes? Is there anything you would like to change?”
 - “In your classes, what kinds of listening tasks are most difficult (e.g., lectures, group discussions, instructions)?”
 - “Outside of class, when do you feel most challenged in listening (e.g., casual conversations, church, work, social events)?”
 - “What kinds of speaking tasks are most difficult (e.g., presentations, group work, asking professors questions, making friends)?”
 - “Which types of speaking tasks do you feel most comfortable with?”
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4. Reading & Writing Skills (20 min)

- “What types of reading are most challenging (e.g., textbooks, online articles, assignments, scriptures, emails)?”
 - “When you write at BYU, what is hardest for you (e.g., grammar, vocabulary, academic style, length of papers)?”
 - “Are there types of writing that are easier or more comfortable?”
 - “What types of reading and writing tasks do you do outside of class?”
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5. Integration & Wrap-Up (10 min)

- “Which English skills do you think are most important for your success here at BYU?”
- “What advice would you give prospective non-native English-speaking students about language skills?”
- “Is there anything we didn’t ask that you think we should know?”

“Thank you for sharing your experiences. Your input will help us better understand how to support international students at BYU. We will send you a copy of the transcript for your review. Please let us know if there are any answers you would like to change. If we don’t hear back from you, we will assume that everything is correct.”

Data Handling

- Use participant codes (e.g., P1, P2).
- Notes or transcripts anonymized before analysis.
- Store data securely.